Fifteen Minutes (from Talking With)

By Jane Martin

A theatrical dressing room. A table and chair. Makeup for the evening's production is laid out on the table. Over the loudspeaker we hear the Stage Manager call, "15 minutes, please. The call is 15 minutes." The actress enters hurriedly and goes to the table. She wears a kimono over a slip. During the course of the piece she completes her makeup and dresses for the play she is doing. Though not actually present she looks into a mirror and thus directly toward the audience. She speaks to an unseen dressing room partner.

INTRODUCTION

All the world's a stage,
And all the men and women merely players;
They have their exits and their entrances,
And one man in his time plays many parts,
You may recognize this as a quote from As You Like It by William Shakespeare, but the words are just as true today as when they were penned in the 16th century. In Fifteen Minutes by Jane Martin we are allowed into the thoughts of a working actress who pours herself out on the literal and figurative stage of life.

ACTRESS: Anyway, this guy, the director, actually used a buzzer. ZZZZZZZZZZ. Really. He would sit there wearing a Yankee's baseball cap and push this buzzer after each laugh line for as long as he thought the laugh would last. Laugh line. ZZZZZZZZZ. This was to train us not to step on the laugh. Can you believe it? Really. Oh, he trained us, believe me. The show opens, there are no laughs but we are waiting for the buzzer. A two-hour play lasted three hours while we paused for laughs that didn't exist. I aged seven years in a night. Directors! Last year I did Katrin in Mother Courage for this really *dour*, silent, unapproachable, East German woman. She sat on a camp stool, immovable, for hours during rehearsal. With her eyes closed yet. No reactions. Really. I felt like a radio show. Anyway, after a week she asks me out for a beer and

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suggests that we should sleep together to get in tune with the play. I tell her she wants to get in tune with the play she should sleep with the author. She says, 'My dear, Bertholt has been dead for thirty years!' I said, 'In that case you're perfect for each other.'

(S)HE called fifteen right? My! Soooooo, we're really going to do this? Of course we are. It's really mysterious, you know? I mean they're already out there right? Sitting out there. Eating little candies. Peering in pocket mirrors. Who are they? Who knows. What are they expecting? Who knows. We do it. They watch it. We finish. They applaud. They go home. We go home. What was it? Who knows.

What I want to know, is how the hell do they live in a town like this without a decent Chinese restaurant?

O.K., O.K., O.K., O.K., ... so, it's fifteen and I am in here getting ready for an evening of 'lacerating self exposure' and there are people out there reading the program, reading my bio, you know getting a little personal insight, getting to know me. And what I want to know . . . you think this is enough eyes for this house? Great. And what I want to know is who are *they?* Fair's fair, right?

What I would like other than some decent light in this dressing room what I would like is a program delivered to me every night with bio's of the audience, you know, so we'd start out even ... I am really a mutt, you know it? ... where they live, last play they saw, favorite color, sexual preference, last relationship they screwed up, you know just basic stuff. Because then we'd be in this together, right? I do a little lacerating self exposure, they do a little

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lacerating self exposure and afterwards who knows maybe we get together for a drink, because then ... O.K., what you see is what you get ... because then there would be an exchange, an exchange and not this unilateral crap, this "I'm in the light, you're in the dark" stuff, which truth to tell is beginning to wear on me. Me. Moira, the semi-Taurus from Julliard, with two Broadway credits, this baby, and an unreleased horror film where I am eaten by stone griffins on the towers of Notre Dame.

(Stage Manager's voice: "5 *minutes. The call* is 5 *minutes, please.")* Right; five minutes, right. *(SHE begins to put on her clothes.)* I mean I have nothing against these people, these humans who have paid their money, some would say too much money, for an evening of ... for an evening of ... *(SHE pauses a moment transfixed by a memory.)* Entertainment. Wow. Y'ever think of it like that ... what you are, you, are an entertainment? I strike me as a number of things, but I do not strike me as ... look, what I would like ... once ... just after my entrance, is to walk downstage ... *(SHE does, right to the footlights.)* and say, "Excuse me. Excuse me, could we have the house lights for a second please?" *(They come up.)* Hey, O.K., thanks. And I would like to look at them, the people who seriously believe that I am an entertainment ... Hi ... How are you? I would just *look* at them, you know, take them in ... *(SHE does. A fairly long pause.)* And then I would say ... see this would be better already ... I mean it's better to have seen their faces. I would say that I'm ... a little fragile ... freaked out, you know ... sort of at the end of a personal relationship ... I mean not the character, well I mean the character is too but ... you've all been through that, right? The end of a crucial relationship? You know, the self-doubt and everything ... the feeling that you're not lovable ... that you're a

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mutt, too much of a mutt to be loved . . . and that you have . . . I don't know. . . a crisis of confidence ... is that a good description?

That it's hard to *act* ... hard to be the entertainment for people you don't know ... haven't looked at. So I just needed to see you tonight, O.K.? Just see you for a minute. That's all ... O.K.? *(The stage manager calls places: "Places, please. The call is places. Places, please." SHE stands a moment longer and then moves back up to the dressing table. The house lights fade.)* Sooooooooo. Hey, O.K.! Ready to Rock-and-Roll, right? Ready to do it in the dark. For whoever and whatever, whoever makes of it. Hey, that's the way it's 'sposed to be. They got a law on this thing. Besides, hey listen, I ain't a mutt. I am *supremely* self-confident. I lacerate with my self exposure. Listen, don't screw with me, they said it in the *newspaper!* I am the entertainment and when lope' my lips, let no dog bark! Plus, fuck 'em if they can't take a joke right? *(SHE checks the mirror one more time.)* And me, hey, I'm the joke! *(SHE loses herself again for a moment, staring in front of her, just for a moment.)* On the other hand, I'm in the light. *(SHE crosses out right. Lights fade out, sound of vacuum, which continues during scene change.)*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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